GEMS OF INDIA

A LARGE HEART FOR AFFORDABLE HEALTHCARE

Narayana Health is revolutionising affordable cardiac care across the country with low-cost insurance plans

By **AJAY SUKUMARAN**

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **The company performed over 21,000 cardiac surgeries in FY24, making it one of India's largest private heart care institutes**
- **Dr Shetty pioneered an insurance scheme for affordable and quality healthcare that the Karnataka govt adopted in 600 hospitals**
- **He now envisions health savings accounts for workers in the unorganised sector**

The founding credo of Narayana Health is simple. "If a solution is not affordable, it is not a solution. There is no point in me talking about all the developments in heart care if the common man can't afford it," says Dr Devi Prasad Shetty, the heart surgeon who has transformed cardiac care in India with his single-minded pursuit of providing quality healthcare at low prices. When he founded Narayana Health in 2000, Dr Shetty wanted to build a facility that could serve working-class people and be capable of performing 60 major heart surgeries a day.

Today, Narayana Health's flagship hospital in Bengaluru achieves half of that number alone. In FY24, its three heart centres and 17 hospitals across India carried out over 21,000 cardiac surgeries, making it one of India's largest private heart care institutes. For Dr Shetty, however, it's the bigger picture of Indian healthcare that matters. "We have addressed the access, we are now addressing the affordability," he says.

The anecdote that Dr Shetty often recalls is how, back in 1989, when he returned to India after a stint in England to continue his career in Kolkata, his first patient paid Rs 1.5 lakh for a bypass grafting. Today, more than three decades later, poor patients at Narayana Health pay Rs 2.5 lakh—only about a tenth, adjusted for inflation, and far lower than competitors. This was possible, as Viren Prasad Shetty, executive vice shairman and Dr Shetty's eldest son, explains, by marrying scale with efficiency. "There are trade-offs. Our hospitals are not the fanciest," says Viren. "You don't get a luxury experience, but we make it up... we focus on the core, which is about medical services and how efficiently you can deliver them at international standards."

The group's focus is now on affordable health insurance and preventive care. Dr Shetty pioneered the Yashaswini micro-insurance scheme for farmers back in 2003, which quickly became a role model after being launched by the Karnataka government in 600 hospitals. "Within 12 years, 1.3 million farmers had varieties of surgeries and 130,000 farmers had a cardiac procedure by paying just Rs 5 per month. I can enumerate a number of instances where amazing things happened just by the volume of patients we are able to treat," he says. Now, he is advocating Jan Dhan Yojana-like health savings accounts for employees in the unorganised sector, which he believes will transform healthcare for the masses. ■

BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"Dr Shetty said my father's bypass surgery could wait till he recovered from his stroke. The robotic procedure cost 40 per cent less than at other hospitals. They even further reduced it on my request. That is their approach to patients"

ROHIT RAMMURTHY, *Executive at manufacturing firm*